[DeXter]'s Laboratory

You know the cartoon character. Now meet his real life doppelganger. He guards his lab... er house with joysticks and writes programs to close windows and doors!

Shiv Manas

Upendra Singhai

Shiv Manas' flat in Mumbai's upscale Colaba area could be just about any other accommodation allotted to senior government officials—his father, Damodar Das, is chief marketing manager at Andhra Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation. It is larger than most flats in Mumbai, is subdued, and has the quiet elegance of any south Mumbai apartment.

Shiv, 18, is a second-year engineering student at a Navi Mumbai college. He has a lot of friends in college, and spends most of his time with them. His online nickname: [DeXter]. Yes, including the capital X and the brace brackets. "I don't want to get into some copyright problems with Cartoon Network," he says tongue-in-cheek.

At home, however, he is a different creature. On a day when there is no college, he spends around 18 hours a day on his trusted PC. His PC room is also his den, a place from where he controls his home's security system, which he built on his own.

Guests at the Das household have gotten used to ringing the bell and Shiv getting an e-mail notification, or an alarm bell ringing (if the person at the door is expected beforehand, then the PC is programmed in such a way that the guest hears a welcome sound), or a call going to the Das mobile phone if they are not at home. Depending on Shiv's whim, the PC also sends him an SMS, pages him or sends him a fax.

He calls it a trigger-based security system—he is yet to name his small innovation—and by now his parents are so used to it that they don't even talk about it.

All that Shiv uses is a joystick, an IVR software and a little bit of programming.

How does it work?

The trigger-based security system is just that, but it's Shiv's clever programming that makes it what it is.

If Shiv wants to step out of his house, he enables the system such that whenever a door or window opens or shuts, a switch or a trigger attached to it—a joystick, in this case—gets activated, and PC reacts as programmed.

The triggers are connected to the PC through the game (MIDI) port on the sound card. He has also developed a program that detects any movement by constantly monitoring the game port for 'On' and 'Off' signals. Says Shiv: "An 'On' signal means the door is closed, and an open door gives an 'Off' signal." When someone enters

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